my *boets*, forever on the brink of bursting into tears, and loving every minute. At stages, it felt as if my only purpose in life was to prove that, no matter the odds, no matter what anybody said, I could do what Jan and Wessels could do.

In every single contest, I was stretching every sinew simply to reach their level.

If anybody ever conducts an academic study into the optimal childhood for an elite sports person, they will surely conclude that nothing beats growing up in the slipstream of talented, competitive older siblings.

I owe my brothers almost everything.

Jan is fully nine years older than me and, as a talented opening bowler in the Northern Transvaal Districts cricket team at Nuffield Week, he would have been absolutely entitled to ignore me as a pesky irritant, but he never did. On the contrary, he always engaged with me, motivated me and inspired me.

'Jan, I'll race you. Come on, Jan.'

'What?'

'I'll race you from this tree to that tree over there.'

'Really?'

'Come on!'

We were walking home from church on a Sunday morning in our smart clothes but, ever desperate to compete, I was challenging my eldest brother to an impromptu sprint. Most 20-year-olds would have told me to go away but Jan accepted the challenge. I won and, 20 years later, I'm still savouring the glow of victory.

Jan is now married to Karien, and they have two young children, Benjamin and Karli. He is now the owner of The Purple Trumpet, an outstanding boutique guesthouse in Waterkloof, Pretoria.

Wessels, our middle brother, is six years older than me and, for as long as I can remember, has been a source of comfort to me. As a boy, I remember often waking frightened in the middle of a stormy night and I